

Construction English

From the Site to the Blueprint

ANSWER KEY · 2025 / 2026

90 terms · A1 → C2 · Technical & on-site vocabulary

Contents

This answer key follows the same six levels of the interactive activity. Each section lists every term, its Portuguese translation and the original context (sentence, definition or scenario). Use it to grade student work or as a reference handout after class.

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A1 · 15 terms

Basic vocabulary · Matching English ↔ Portuguese

English	Português
brick	tijolo
wall	parede
roof	telhado
floor	piso
door	porta
window	janela
cement	cimento
sand	areia
wood	madeira
nail	prego
hammer	martelo
paint	tinta
ladder	escada (de mão)
helmet	capacete
tool	ferramenta

A2 · 15 terms

Tools & people on site · Matching term ↔ definition

Term	PT + Definition
bucket	balde A round container used to carry water, sand or cement.
shovel	pá A tool with a long handle used to dig or move sand and dirt.
drill	furadeira An electric tool used to make holes in walls or wood.
screw	parafuso A small metal piece you turn into wood or a wall to fix things.
screwdriver	chave de fenda A hand tool used to put screws in or take them out.
tile	azulejo / cerâmica A flat, hard square piece used to cover floors, walls or roofs.
pipe	cano A long round tube that carries water or gas inside a building.
wire	fio elétrico A thin metal line used to carry electricity.
saw	serra A tool with sharp teeth used to cut wood or metal.
brush	pincel A tool with bristles used to apply paint to a surface.
glove	luva A piece of clothing that protects your hands while working.
boot	bota A heavy, strong shoe worn for safety on the construction site.
site	canteiro de obra The place where a building is being built.
worker	operário A person whose job is to build or repair things.

Term	PT + Definition
cement mixer	betoneira A machine that turns to mix cement, sand and water.

B1 · 15 terms

Real construction English in context · Fill-in with word bank

Answer	Sentence	PT
scaffolding	The painters can't reach the upper floors without <u>scaffolding</u> around the building.	andaime
blueprint	The architect handed me the <u>blueprint</u> so I could see the layout of the second floor.	planta / projeto
foundation	Before any walls go up, we have to pour the concrete <u>foundation</u> .	fundação
beam	A heavy steel <u>beam</u> runs across the ceiling to support the floor above.	viga
column	Each <u>column</u> in the parking garage carries the weight of the entire building.	pilar
concrete	The <u>concrete</u> truck arrives at 7 a.m. — the slab needs to be poured before noon.	concreto
plaster	Once the bricks are in place, we apply <u>plaster</u> to make the walls smooth.	reboco
plumbing	Don't close the walls yet — the <u>plumbing</u> hasn't been inspected.	encanamento
wiring	Faulty <u>wiring</u> is the most common cause of fires in old buildings.	fiação elétrica
insulation	We're adding extra <u>insulation</u> in the roof to keep the house cool in summer.	isolamento
crane	The <u>crane</u> lifts the steel beams up to the seventh floor.	guindaste
wheelbarrow	Pedro pushes a <u>wheelbarrow</u> full of bricks across the site every morning.	carrinho de mão
measuring tape	Use the <u>measuring tape</u> to check the door is exactly 80 centimeters wide.	trena
level	Place the <u>level</u> on top of the shelf to make sure it's perfectly horizontal.	nível (ferramenta)

Answer	Sentence	PT
safety harness	Anyone working above three meters must wear a <u>safety harness</u> at all times.	cinto de segurança

B2 · 15 terms

Technical vocab + on-site language · Flashcards

Term	PT	Meaning & Example
rebar	vergalhão	Steel reinforcement bar placed inside concrete to give it tensile strength. <i>e.g. "The rebar has to be tied up before the concrete pour starts tomorrow."</i>
formwork	fôrma	Temporary mold (usually wood or steel) that holds wet concrete until it sets. <i>e.g. "Don't strip the formwork off the columns until the concrete has cured."</i>
drywall	drywall / gesso acartonado	Lightweight panels of plaster used to build interior walls quickly. <i>e.g. "We're putting up drywall today and skim-coating tomorrow."</i>
grout	rejunte	The filler paste that goes between tiles after they're laid. <i>e.g. "Wait 24 hours before you grout — the tiles need to set first."</i>
mortar	argamassa	The mix of cement, sand and water used to bond bricks or stones together. <i>e.g. "Mix a fresh batch of mortar — that one is too dry to work with."</i>
load-bearing wall	parede portante	A wall that carries the weight of the floors or roof above it. <i>e.g. "You can't knock that down — it's a load-bearing wall."</i>
snag list	lista de pendências	A list of small defects that need to be fixed before the project is handed over. <i>e.g. "The client walked through yesterday and added six items to the snag list."</i>
punch list	lista de pendências (US)	American English for snag list — final defects to fix before handover. <i>e.g. "We're 95% done — just the punch list to clear."</i>
subcontractor	subempreiteiro	A specialized company hired by the main contractor for one part of the job. <i>e.g. "The electrical subcontractor is two days behind schedule."</i>

Term	PT	Meaning & Example
foreman	mestre de obras	The person in charge of the workers on the site day-to-day. <i>e.g. "Talk to the foreman — he decides who works on which floor."</i>
backfill	reaterro	To fill an excavated area back in with soil or gravel after work is done. <i>e.g. "Once the foundation is cured, we'll backfill around it."</i>
demo	demolição	Short for 'demolition' — tearing something down to make space for new work. <i>e.g. "Demo starts Monday — the old kitchen has to come out before we can frame the new one."</i>
jobsite	canteiro de obra (US)	The general area where construction is happening — used in everyday US site talk. <i>e.g. "Coffee at six, on the jobsite by seven."</i>
skim coat	massa fina	A thin final layer of plaster applied to smooth a wall before painting. <i>e.g. "Give it a skim coat before you start painting."</i>
caulk	silicone (selante)	A flexible filler used to seal joints between materials. <i>e.g. "Run a bead of caulk along the bathtub edge."</i>

C1 · 15 terms

Engineering & project management · Multiple choice

Answer	Sentence	PT
Load-bearing capacity	The structural engineer is checking whether the new mezzanine exceeds the floor's maximum safe weight.	capacidade de carga
Structural integrity	After the earthquake, inspectors evaluated whether the building was still safe to occupy.	integridade estrutural
Bill of quantities (BOQ)	Before pricing the project, the contractor needs a detailed list of every material and quantity required.	planilha quantitativa
Cantilever	The balcony extends 2.5 meters past the building's last support, with no column underneath it.	balanço estrutural
Retaining wall	To stop the soil from sliding down onto the road below, the project needs this kind of wall.	muro de arrimo / contenção
Expansion joint	Long concrete slabs include intentional gaps so they can move slightly with temperature changes.	junta de dilatação
Waterproofing	Before the basement walls go up, the team applies a membrane to prevent water from seeping through.	impermeabilização
As-built drawings	After construction is complete, the contractor delivers updated drawings showing exactly how the building was built.	projeto as-built / executado
RFI (Request for Information)	The contractor needs clarification on a detail in the architect's drawings and sends a formal written question.	pedido formal de esclarecimento de projeto
Dead load	The permanent weight of the building itself — walls, slabs, roof.	carga permanente
Live load	The variable weight of furniture, people and equipment that the building must carry.	carga acidental / variável
Shoring	Before excavating next to an existing foundation, the team installs temporary supports to keep the soil and structure stable.	escoramento

Answer	Sentence	PT
Critical path	In the project schedule, the sequence of tasks that determines the shortest possible project duration.	caminho crítico
Change order	The owner asks for an additional bathroom not included in the contract; the contractor issues a formal request.	ordem de modificação contratual
Soil bearing capacity	Before construction starts, geotechnical engineers test how much weight the soil can safely support.	capacidade de suporte do solo

C2 · 15 terms

High-level construction & contract vocabulary · Type the term

Answer	Sentence	PT
Value engineering	A formal process during design where alternative materials and methods are reviewed to deliver the same function at lower cost without sacrificing quality.	engenharia de valor
Constructability	How easily and efficiently a design can actually be built on site.	construtibilidade
Lean construction	A construction philosophy adapted from Toyota's manufacturing system that focuses on eliminating waste and maximizing value.	construção enxuta
Contingency allowance	An amount added to the budget to cover unexpected costs or risks.	reserva para contingências
Liquidated damages	Pre-agreed financial penalties paid by the contractor for every day a project is delivered late.	multa contratual por atraso
Specifications (specs)	The technical specifications attached to a contract, describing standards, materials and workmanship in detail.	especificações técnicas
Force majeure	A contractual clause that protects the parties when extraordinary events outside their control prevent performance.	força maior
MEP (mechanical, electrical, plumbing)	The collective term for a building's mechanical, electrical and plumbing systems.	instalações prediais
Building envelope	Everything that physically separates the conditioned interior of a building from the outside — walls, roof, windows, foundation.	envoltória do edifício
Commissioning	The systematic process of testing and verifying that all building systems perform as designed before handover to the owner.	comissionamento

Answer	Sentence	PT
Defects liability period	The contractually defined period after handover during which the contractor must repair defects that emerge.	período de garantia / responsabilidade por defeitos
Notice to Proceed (NTP)	The formal written instruction from the owner authorizing the contractor to officially start work.	ordem de início de obra
Prequalification	The vetting stage where contractors must demonstrate financial, technical and safety capability before being allowed to bid on a project.	pré-qualificação
Punchlist walkthrough	The final inspection where the owner walks the project with the contractor and lists every remaining defect to be corrected.	vistoria de pendências
Critical Path Method (CPM)	The scheduling technique that identifies the longest sequence of dependent tasks.	método do caminho crítico

End of answer key

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